that will envelop the planet with lethal radioactivity. The plot of the film revolves around attempts to recall the 843rd Bomb Wing and then, when one aircraft is not recalled, the attempts to shoot it down. The US Strategic Air Command (SAC) denied such a breakdown in the command and control of its nuclear weapons was possible. The idea of a Doomsday Machine that can be automatically triggered sounds very much the stuff of science fiction. Or at least it was until it became known that the Soviets actually sought to develop a technological solution to the vulnerabilities of their command and control systems (known as Perimeter) to provide at least a semi-automatic system for ensuring retaliation.[21]

Dr Strangelove ends with Vera Lynn singing 'We'll Meet Again' as mushroom clouds announce the detonation of the Doomsday Machine. Mushroom clouds are also employed at the beginning of *Thirteen Days*, Hollywood's rendition of the Cuban missile crisis (starring and co-produced by Kevin Costner).[22] Some reviews of the film by historians were positive.[23] A leading expert on Cuban-US relations, Philip Brenner, however, took strong exception to the representation of events. He noted it will be 'the one film about the missile crisis from which at least a generation of students will learn the crisis's lessons … This movie feeds the worst American jingoism. They should have warned us. Its lessons are dangerous to your health.'[24]

The producers of *Thirteen Days* maintained their work was based on the 1997 book *The Kennedy Tapes*, edited by Ernest May and Philip Zelikow, composed from transcripts of White House meetings in September and October 1962.[25] The title of the film, however, is that of Robert Kennedy's memoir, published in 1969. In 1962 RFK was the US Attorney General, though his brother used him in various ways, not least to lead efforts to destabilise and overthrow Fidel Castro (see chapter two). Robert Kennedy knew his brother more intimately than anyone else in the administration. His memoir quickly became a reference point in studies of the crisis, and, along with accounts from other senior officials, helped shape the dominant narratives of the events.[26]